

Comperative Politics

Meaning:- The study and comparison of power across the countries.

Introduction:-

It is the branch of political science that studies and compares the political systems of different countries. Its purpose to understand how governments work, how power is exercised and why political systems differ from one country to another.

It looks at things like:

- Government & constitutions
- Political institutions & parties
- Political Behaviour & Culture
- Stability, Change, and development

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Definitions :-

1. Almond & Powell :-

It is the study of political systems through comparison, focusing on how different political structures perform similar political functions in various societies.

2. Patrick H. O'Neil :-

It is the systematic study & comparison of political systems, with emphasis on institutions, actors & processes.

General Definition :-

Comparative politics is the systematic study & comparison of political systems of different countries to understand how power is organized, exercised & changed.

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Explanation:-

- Comparative politics compares government, institutions and political process of various state.
- It studies similarities & differences among political system
- It explains why political systems work differently in different societies.
 - It's study based on observations
 - It is comparative study & analysis not study of authority, election or other.
 - It's study based on reason, logic & comparison means scientific.
 - It also include :
 - Political System
 - Political Ideas
 - Pal. Culture
 - Pal. Philosophy
- Political culture: way of life
 - Example: High Voting & trust in government in Scandinavian countries
 - Low political participation in developing countries.

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Political Ideology:

Practical belief

Followed by parties & leaders

Examples

- Capitalism in USA

- Socialism in China

Liberalism & Individualism Vs

Socialism Ideology Comparison

Golden Rule : Objectivity

Methodology:-

Comparative politics

is based on observation, surveys and research

Problem of Bias:-

Bias means

personal liking or disliking

Example:

If a researcher like Imran Khan & studies him the research becomes emotional not scientific. So Avoid it.

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Freedom & Equality:

This answers: How different systems balance freedom & equality?

This is core comparative analysis

① Liberal Democracy: USA & UK

- High Freedom ↑ F
- Low Equality ↓ E

Reason: Free market creates inequality

② Social Democracy: (Scandinavian Countries)

- High / Medium Freedom ↑ F
- High Equality ↑ E

Reason: Welfare Society + democracy

③ Communism: (USSR / Leninism)

- No Freedom
 - High Equality (dangerous)
- because equality is forced & freedom is suppressed.

④ Fascism (Italy): ↓ F ↓ Equality

Power concentrated in the state & leader

Category: Comparison of Pol. System based on values.

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Anarchism:-

- No state
- No private property
- No religion

Claims:

- High Freedom
 - High Equality
- => It is called "Ultra-liberalism"
- => Opposes communism & state control

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Methods Used in Com.Pol

There are some methods of comparative politics which are following

1. Comparative Method:-

This method compares many countries at the same time.

Its main purpose to find similarities, differences and general patterns.

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Example:

Comparing Political System
of the USA, UK, France

2. Case Study Method:

This method refers to an individual case or specific case.

It includes one country or pair of countries in depth.

It's main purpose to understand causes, processes, and outcomes.

Examples-

Comparing North Korea & South Korea to explain different political paths.

e.g Why a democracy evolved in South Korea and dictatorship evolved in North Korea.

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3. Statistical Method/Quantitative

This method use data, numbers and statistics.

It's main purpose to make comparison more scientific & measurable.

Examples:-

Comparing voter turnout or literacy rates across countries

Comparing of GDP from (1-10 years) of England & Finland

Note: All the other methods are qualitative method except quantitative method.

4. Historical Method:-

All methods such as comparative method, case study method, qualitative are based on historical method.

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This method studies political systems through historical development
 ⇒ It's main purpose to understand how past events shape present politics.

Example:

Studying the French Revolution to explain modern French democracy.

5. Experimental Method:

Means studying politics by testing cause and effect under controlled conditions.

You have to deviate from totally theoretical approach.

→ Also known as social experiment

Many Types:-

→ Survey experiments

→ Natural experiments

→ Field experiments

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Approach Towards Com.Pol

Meaning:-

An approach means a way of studying or analyzing politics

It tells us:

- What to focus on
- How to study it
- What questions to ask

⇒ An approach is the method or perspective used to understand political system.

1. Traditional Approach:

The traditional approach is the old way of studying politics.

Main Focus:-

- Constitution
- Laws
- Formal structures
- Government Institutions

It mainly studied:

- Legislation
- Executive
- Judiciary

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Philosophical Approach:-

The philosophical approach is a part of traditional approach.

It studies politics through:

- Ideas
- Values
- Moral principles.

It asks:

→ What is justice?

→ What is the ideal state?

→ What should government do?

⇒ It focuses on political thinkers and their theories rather than real political behavior.

2. Modern Approach:-

Modern approach developed after World War II. Scholars realized politics is not just about institutions.

Main Focus:-

- Political behavior
- Political culture
- Political development
- Social & economic factors

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Aristotle : Comp Approach

Aristotle was one of the earliest thinkers who used comparison in politics.

Explanation:

- He studied & compared 158 constitutions of Greek city-states

- He analyzed different forms of government.

→ He laid the foundation of comparative politics by using comparison to study pol. system.

Historical Approach:

It explains present political conditions by examining past events.

It argues that you can't understand why a country has liberty (or lacks it) without looking at its history.

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Example

Case study: Liberty

Comparison b/w Europe & the Middle East.

Europe has more pol. liberty, freedom of speech, voting rights than middle East where less political liberty.

Institutional Approach

Comparison of formal political institutions of different countries.

Main Focus:

- Parliament • Executive • Judiciary
- Constitution • Structure of government

Example:-

Europe: • Parliamentary democracy
• Democratic Institutions

Middle East: • Authoritarian government
• Weak democratic institutions.

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Legal Approaches:-

Meaning:-

The legal approach studies politics through laws & legal frameworks

Key Idea:

- Laws are the outcome of politics

- Laws are an integral part of every society

Focus:

→ Constitution

→ legal structure

→ Human rights

Example

India:- More legal protection for women's rights.

Iran:- More restrictions on women's rights.

⇒ This approach compares countries based on legal provisions.

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Modern Approaches:

1. Behaviouralism
2. System Theory
3. Structural Functional Approach
4. Political Culture Approach
5. Political Economy "
6. Marxist Approach.

1. Behaviouralism:

Studies individual political behaviour & psychological factors.

Focus :-

- Leaders' personalities
- Voting behavior
- Political attitude

Example:

• Hitler • Lenin • Churchill etc

Key Idea:-

Politics is influenced by human behavior, not just institutions.

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2. System Approach: (David Easton)

Politics is viewed as a system of inputs & outputs.

Core Elements:

- Inputs → Demands & Support
- Outputs → Government decisions
- Feedback → Public reaction

Key Idea:

The political system is interconnected & works like a cycle.

3. Structural-Functionalism

It analyzes political structures & their functions.

Structures:

- Political parties
- Interest groups
- Pressure groups

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Important Concepts:

- Interest Articulation → Expressing demands
- Interest Aggregation → Combining demands.

Note:

- Every pressure group is an interest group but not every group is a pressure group.
- ⇒ All structures are interconnected.

Political Economy Approach:

Studies the relationship b/w politics & economy.

Key Focus:-

- State & Wealth
- How economy influences politics
- How politics shapes the economy

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Example:-

Case Study: Finland & UK

Examine how economic systems affect political decisions.

• Comparative Politics:

Pol. System & System Approach

Introduction:-

Comparative politics studies political systems in a modern and systematic way

① • Traditional approaches: focused mainly on institutions (rules & laws)

Limitations: They neglected the actual relationships b/w different parts of the system & how the system interacts with the outside environment.

Solution: At the end of 19th century this modern views politics as a living breathing entity rather than just a set of buildings or laws.

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2. Institutional Approach:

- Focused on formal institution (e.g. parliament, executive, courts)
- Ignored interaction b/w different parts of the system & outside environment.

3. System Approach:-

- Developed end of 19th century / early 20th century
- Response to limitations of the institutional approach.

Meaning: Break the system into subsystems, study each, then understand the whole.

Definition of System:-

- A structural & functional organization consisting of units or parts
- Units are interconnected but can function independently
- Together, they form an integrated whole to achieve objectives.

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Examples:

- Society → Subsystems: family, clubs —
- State → Subsystem: pol. parties, unions, legal institutions & trade etc

Purpose of System Analysis

- To study relationships within the pol. system.
- To understand interactions b/w subsystems
- To explain pol. outcomes e.g. instability or development.

The Historical Expansion of the Study

Historically the "Area of Interest" for political scholars was very small because of global power dynamics:

1. Early Era: Focused on North America & Europe due to Imperial & colonial powers. Scholars focused on liberal democracy & capitalism

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While ignoring the rest of the world

2. Middle Era:

Focused on: Russia, Germany, Italy

Reason: The rise of communism (Russia)

Nazism (Germany), Fascism (Italy)

Insured scholars to expand their study to different types of systems.

3. The Third Wave:

The third wave focused on Asia, Africa & South America,

• Decolonization allowed these regions to become independent and create their own countries making the study comparative politics truly global.

Society & Social System:

Society is the total structure of human life. Consists of

- Economy
- Politics
- Education
- Culture

Different sectors but connected

⇒ Social system is the main system includes economy, politics, education etc

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Political System:

A political system is:

- A network of individuals, groups, and organizations.
- Connected through interactions and mutual relationship.
- Having the authority to make & enforce rules, laws & decisions.
- It includes:

→ Government institutions

→ Administrative agencies

→ Political structures

→ Political Actors

⇒ So it is not just parliament, courts but includes parties, pressure groups, public opinion; everything involved in Power.

Components of Pol. System

Every structure performs a function to keep the system is stable.

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1. Pol. Structure:

These are the visible organizations

→ Government institutions

→ Pol. parties, Interest groups

2. Pol. Function

• The roles & actions performed by pol. Actors

Example:-

• Law making • Policy implementation

• Conflict Resolution

⇒ Structure is the body. Function is what the body does

Political Process:- Culture

This is

• Patterns of interaction b/w pol. Actors

• Values, beliefs, attitude of people towards politics.

• Without Pol. Culture system can't survive. Example:-

• Trust in government

• Respect for law etc.

Political Process:-

This explains ~~why~~ how the system works step by step.

a. Interactions:

- Cooperation ◦ Competition
- Co-optation

Inputs

Demand & Supports
 → Rights, claims, justice
 → Public opinion, Expert opinion, opposition
 ⇒ Inputs are what society sends to Pol. system

Outputs:

Outputs are what the system produces.

- Decisions ◦ policies ◦ Rules/Law

Feedback:

- Society reacts to output
- Feedback improves future decision
- If policy fail, new demand arise.

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Levels of Pol System

Political Systems operate at different level, from individual to global system. Each level influence the others

1. Individual Pol System (Micro level)

The most basic level of the political system is the individual citizen

Role :-

Individual participate in politics

as :

- Citizens
- Voters/Electorate

Factors Influencing Individuals:-

Political choices are shaped by:

- Culture
- Family
- Education
- Social Environment
- Community Values

Example:-

A voter may support a pol. party because:

Their family supports it

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2. Decision-Making Subsystems (Institutional Level)

These are organizations that influence pol. decisions inside a country.

Includes:-

- Government institutions
- Pol. Parties
- Interest Groups & Pressure

Function:

These actors:

- Express public demands
- Influence policy
- Participate in governance

Example:-

- Parliament passing laws
- Pol. Parties forming government
- • Pressure groups lobbying for policy change
- These institutions form subsystems of the national pol. system

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3. National Political System (state level)

Each sovereign state develops its own pol. System to govern society

Characteristics:

- Independent authority
- Government institutions
- Laws & policies
- Pol. Structures

Requirement:-

The state should be,

→ Modern → Sovereign

Example:-

- Pakistan's parliamentary system
- USA's presidential system

⇒ The national political system organizes political life within a country.

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4. International Pol. System (Global level)

This level involves relations b/w different states

The main actors are states

Characteristics:-

- Cooperation & conflict b/w states
- No strong global authority
- Often described as a weak pol. system

Examples:-

- United Nations
- Diplomatic relations b/w countries
- International treaties

⇒ Because the world is no world government, the international system is considered weak or decentralized

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Principles Used to classify Pol. Systems:

1. Principle of Democracy:

This checks how much
people participate in politics

If a system has:

- Free election
- Pol. Parties
- Interest groups
- Public participation

→ It is democratic

→ If these are absent & power
is concentrated in rulers →
then non-democratic

Examples:

- US - democratic
- North Korea - non-democratic

2. Principle of Modernity:-

This checks social &
economic development

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Modern system usually have

- Industrialization
- Urbanization
- Modern institutions
- Advanced education & technology

Its society is dominated by:

- tribes
- clans → feudal elites
- ⇒ It is traditional

Types of Pol. Systems

1. Traditional Non-Democratic System:

No Democracy & Modernity

Characteristics:-

- Society based on tribes, clans, feudal structures
- Customs, Religion & Tradition dominant
- Monarch or ruler controls

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power

- People don't participate in politics

Example:

- Saudi Arabia (traditional monarchy)
- Pre-modern kingdoms

2. Traditional Democratic System:

- Democracy present but no proper modernity
- Elections & political participation exists

- Society is still influenced by caste, tribe, religion, elites

Example:

India is democratic, but caste & social hierarchy still influenced politics

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3. Modern[↓] Democratic System

Modern state but no democracy

Characteristics:

- Industrialized & modern state
- Strong bureaucracy & technology
- but pol. freedom is limited

Ruled by:

- Military dictatorship or
- Single Pol. Party

Example: • China • North Korea

Two forms → • Authoritarianism
→ • Totalitarianism

4. Modern Democratic System:

- Both democracy & Modernity

Characteristics:

- free elections
- strong institutions → rule of law
- Developed economy

Examples:-

US , UK , Germany